

RESHAPING INDIA'S POLITICAL MAP

Medieval Period, Delhi Sultanate, Regional Resistance & The Mughal Empire

1. MEDIEVAL PERIOD OVERVIEW

Understanding the Medieval Period

Europe

Starts from the Fall of Rome (5th CE) to the Renaissance.

India

Not the same as Europe. Refers to the period between 11th and 17th CE.

2. INVASIONS FROM BEYOND THE HINDU KUSH

WHO

Turkic or Afghan invaders

WHEN

Early 11th Century CE

WHY

To spread religion, establish political control & enjoy the riches of India

3. START OF ISLAMIC RULE & DELHI SULTANATE

- Established through the **Second Battle of Tarain (1192)**, where Muhammad Ghori defeated Prithviraj Chauhan (Chahamanas).
- This victory paved the direct path for the establishment of the Delhi Sultanate.

Chronological Dynasties of the Delhi Sultanate

1. Mamluk / Slave
(1206 – 1290)

2. Khalji Dynasty
(1290 – 1320)

3. Tughlaq Dynasty
(1320 – 1414)

4. Sayyid Dynasty
(1414 – 1451)

5. Lodi Dynasty
(1451 – 1526)

Key Rulers of the Mamluk Dynasty:

- Qutb-ud-din Aibak:** Founder of the Mamluk dynasty; initiated construction of the Qutub Minar.
- Iltutmish:** Completed the construction of Qutub Minar and consolidated the Sultanate.
- Raziya:** The first female ruler of the Delhi Sultanate.
- Ghiyas-ud-din Balban:** Strengthened central power and introduced Persian customs/court etiquette.

4. KEY FEATURES OF THE DELHI SULTANATE

- Violent Successions:** Frequent internal bloody wars for the throne after a Sultan died.
- Short Reigns:** The average reign of a ruler was approximately 9 years.
- Suffering of Common People:** Heavy taxation, agricultural distress, and widespread raids, plunder, loot, and destruction of temples during campaigns.

- **Political Instability:** Unstable administration caused by weak rulers, rebellious nobles, and the absence of a fixed hereditary law of succession.

"Golden Age" / Peak Expansion under Ala-ud-din Khalji:

- Achieved peak territorial expansion of the Sultanate, extending rule deep into South India.
- Ruled with an iron hand, enforcing strict price controls and market regulations.
- Successfully repulsed multiple major Mongol attacks on India.

5. MUHAMMAD BIN TUGHLAQ & FOREIGN ATTACKS

Muhammad bin Tughlaq:

- Known as a "*mixture of opposites*" due to visionary ideas poorly executed.
- **Geographic Peak:** Under his reign, the empire reached its highest geographical extent across the subcontinent.
- **Capital Transfer:** Shifted the capital from Delhi to Daulatabad (Devagiri) and back, causing immense hardships to people.
- **New Policies:** Introduced token currency and ambitious tax reforms which failed due to counterfeit coins and administrative oversights.
- **Ibn Battuta:** Famous Moroccan traveler visited India during his reign and documented detailed accounts.

Timur's Invasion (1398):

- Timur (Tamerlane) was a brutal Turkic-Mongol ruler of Central Asia.
- Invaded Northern India with the objective to attack, plunder, kill, and carry immense riches back to Samarkand, leaving Delhi devastated.

6. RESISTANCE TO THE DELHI SULTANATE

Major Kingdoms Resisting Sultanate Expansion

Hoysalas

Mewar (Rajputs)

Vijayanagar Empire

Eastern Ganga
Kingdom (Kalinga)

Bahmani Sultanate

Vijayanagar Empire Highlights:

- Founded by brothers **Harihara I** and **Bukka Raya I** in 1336.
- Patronized art and grand Dravidian architecture (e.g., the famous **Vithala Temple** at Hampi).
- Reached its peak under **Krishnadevaraya**; maintained flourishing international trade connections with Europeans (Portuguese).
- Rivalled the Gajapati Kingdom of Odisha and neighboring Bahmani / Deccan Sultanates; came to an end following defeat in the **Battle of Talikota (1565)**.

7. THE MUGHAL EMPIRE — ORIGIN & TIMELINE

- Founded by **Babur** (a Turkic-Mongol ruler) after defeating Ibrahim Lodi in the **First Battle of Panipat (1526)**.

- **Baburnama:** In his autobiography, Babur depicts himself as an intellectual, curious, cultured ruler, and lover of nature/art; historically, he was also a ruthless military strategist who utilized modern gunpowder technology (guns, cannons).

Chronological Timeline of Mughal Rulers & Key Events

- 1530:** Start of **Humayun's** reign, who struggled to keep the newly formed empire together amidst Afghan challenges.
- 1540:** Start of **Sher Shah Suri's** reign (Suri Dynasty), introducing administrative, land revenue, and infrastructure reforms (e.g., Sadak-e-Azam / Grand Trunk Road).
- 1555:** End of Suri Dynasty; Return of Humayun from exile in Persia to reclaim the throne.
- 1556:** Death of Humayun. Brief reign of **Hemu (Hemu Vikramaditya)** over Delhi. Defeat of Hemu at the **Second Battle of Panipat**; Start of **Akbar's** reign.
- 1605:** Death of Akbar; Accession of **Jahangir** (reign marked by trade, artistic patronage, influence of Nur Jahan, and execution of Sikh Guru Arjan Dev Ji).
- 1627:** Death of Jahangir; Start of **Shah Jahan's** reign (famous for grand architectural wonders, including building the **Taj Mahal**).
- 1658:** Start of **Aurangzeb's** reign after a war of succession among Shah Jahan's sons.

8. RELIGIOUS POLICIES & FALL OF THE MUGHALS

Akbar's Policy of Universal Peace (Sulh-i-Kul):

- Promoted peace, religious tolerance, and ethics (honesty, justice, peace) applied universally.
- Established the **Maktab Khana** (House of Translation) at his capital, **Fatehpur Sikri**, to translate ancient Indian epics (Mahabharata, Ramayana) into Persian.

Fall of Mughals under Aurangzeb:

- Drained empire resources in prolonged, grueling campaigns in the Deccan against Marathas.
- Strict religious orthodoxy, reversing earlier policies of tolerance, imposing Jizya, and destroying prominent temples, causing widespread regional uprisings.

9. DETAILED REGIONAL RESISTANCE TO MUGHALS

A. The Rajputs:

- **Mewar Resistance:** Maharana Pratap refused Mughal allegiance, fighting courageously at the **Battle of Haldighati (1576)** to uphold independence.
- **Mughal Policy:** Akbar secured loyalty from several Rajput clans through diplomatic alliances and high administrative posts (*Mansabs*), though independent principalities continued active resistance.

B. The Gonds (Gondwana Region):

- **Location & Society:** Lived in *Gondwana* ("country inhabited by Gonds"); practiced shifting cultivation (*jhum*). Divided into clans ruled by a *Raja* or *Rai*.
- **Administrative Division:** Divided into **Garhs** (ruled by a clan) → subdivided into **Chaurasis** (84 villages) → further divided into **Barhots** (12 villages each).

- **Garha Katanga:** A rich Gond kingdom (comprising ~70,000 villages mentioned in *Ain-i-Akbari*). Gond rulers sought Rajput status; *Aman Das* adopted the title *Sangram Shah*. His son *Dalpat* married Princess *Durgawati* (a Chandel Rajput princess).
- **Rani Durgawati's Resistance:** As regent for her young son Bir Narain, Rani Durgawati fiercely fought Mughal forces under Asaf Khan in 1565, choosing death over surrender.

C. The Ahoms (Brahmaputra Valley):

- **Establishment:** Migrated from present-day Myanmar in the 13th century, replacing older political systems of *Bhuiyans* (landlords).
- **Paik System:** Relied on compulsory state labor called **Paiks**. Rotated work obligations based on village census figures. Society was structured into clans called **Khels**.
- **Military & History:** Advanced military expertise using firearms and gunpowder early on. Produced detailed historical records called **Buranjis** (written in Ahom and Assamese). Repulsed multiple Mughal expansion attempts into Assam.

D. Other Regional Resistance Groups:

- **Marathas:** Led by Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj, establishing a powerful sovereign empire through strategic guerilla warfare.
- **Sikhs:** Organized into a formidable military-political brotherhood (Khalsa) under Guru Gobind Singh Ji, resisting Mughal tyranny in Punjab.
- **Jats, Bhils, Gonds, Koths, Santals, Ahoms, and Rajputs.**

10. COMPARATIVE ADMINISTRATIVE SYSTEMS

Administration: Delhi Sultanate vs. Mughal Empire

Delhi Sultanate

- **Iqtadari System:** Territory divided into *Iqtas* assigned to military commanders (*Iqtadars* / *Muqtis*).
- **Centralized Power:** Centered strictly around the Sultan.
- **Market & Tax Regulations:** Strict price enforcement, market inspection, and direct collection under Ala-ud-din Khalji.

Mughal Empire

- **Mansabdari & Zamindari Systems:** Rank-based system (*Zat* for rank/salary, *Sawar* for cavalry mandate).
- **Zabt System:** Comprehensive land measurement and revenue assessment system developed by Raja Todar Mal.
- **Centralized Monarchy:** Highly centralized administration around the Mughal Emperor.